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Writing women's worlds

Author(S): Abu-Lughod, Lila**Document Type:** Book**Original Page:** 212**Culture (OWC):** [Libyan Bedouin \(MT09\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Northern Africa**Field Date:** 1978-1989**Coverage Date:** 1978-1989**Place Coverage:** Western Desert, Egypt**Section Title(S):** Arranged Marriage

Kamla is fond of Salih, but he is "like a brother." She and her sisters boldly ask him to get them things they want from town; they reach into his pockets to grab the latest cassettes he has brought for himself. Kamla sometimes teases him, threatening to make him wash the dishes and sweep the floor if he marries her. Kamla even jokes with his mother. I had seen the woman grab Kamla and warn her to be good or else she'd exercise her prospective rights as a mother-in-law and make her quit school. Kamla broke free easily, laughing as she shouted defiantly, "Not until I come to live with you!"

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Women in the camp mutter that Salih is not right for Kamla. Even her grandmother half supports her. Although Migdim tries to persuade her granddaughters of the virtues of marrying cousins, she is angry with her sons for wanting "what nothing good will come of"—this set of matches within the family between children who have grown up together and say they feel like siblings. She fumed, "Her father wants Kamla for Salih, and Kamla says she won't marry him. And Salih says he won't marry Kamla. She's older than he is!"

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Her unmarried granddaughters enjoy provoking Migdim by maligning cousin marriage. They say they want out: they want to marry men who live far away so they can have new lives.

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“They’re good for nothing!” insisted one of Kamla’s cousins once about her male cousins.

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Migdim scolded her, “You slut! What is this outrage? You gypsy!”

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